

Shadows of Titan

He smiled down at her and laid her head gently down against him. Within seconds, Myth was asleep in his arms.

Chapter 7

The morning came swiftly, but she was prepared. Myth stood looking hard into the mirror, watching her bodysuit shift in the soft light. It was matte black and trimmed with silver coils of soft Kinetic thread, each pulsing faintly. Her inky hair, in traditional Verdant fashion, lay half up and threaded with thick coils of violet cords that had been carefully crafted by Lyra. She was calmer than she thought she was going to be. She was ready.

A low pulse of energy signalled his arrival before she saw him. Vexal leaned against the door frame, coat thrown over his shoulder, rot curling faintly in the air like smoke. Remnants of last night, it seemed.

“It’s time,” he said, his voice low, eyes appraising every inch of her. She nodded and followed him through the Big O, her new boots weirdly quiet against the metal floor. Lyra stood

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near the exit, arms crossed tight, face apprehensive. “We would walk you there,” she jutted her chin toward Korric. “But we are pretty popular criminally.”

Korric’s smirk was devoid of humour. “Don’t get yourself killed, kid.” he said gruffly.

“I’ll try not to.” Myth gave him a reassuring smile before pulling her hood up and stepping out into the cold of the Undercity. Vexal didn’t speak much; they moved through the hidden routes and narrow crawlspaces. When they emerged into a thin maintenance tunnel in Helion’s Luminal district, she was completely lost. He finally stopped in front of a door and turned to her, placing his hands on her shoulders. “You are Nyx. Nobody important. Just a forgotten embryo looking to climb the rung of her caste. Let them see what they expect. Let them underestimate you.”

She nodded once. “I understand.”

“You don’t just need to win,” he said, dropping his hands and lifting her chin. “You need to belong. They’ll test everything. And they are **always** watching.”

“I won’t slip,” she said.

He studied her for a long second before nodding. “I know.” And just like that, he was gone, swallowed into the shadows like he’d never been there.

Myth squared her shoulders and stepped out of the tunnel and was almost hit in the face by the gates.

Massive emerald and sapphire doors hummed with Kinetic pressure. Beyond them, she could feel the Apex Testing Grounds thrumming with raw pressure. Carved in the side of a crystalline cliff in the outer rim of Helion Prime, the area stretched wide like a scar against Titan’s skin. Pale auroras shimmered across the fractured sky overhead, painting the shifting transports below in colours that didn’t exist for Dregs. Machinery groaned beneath stone,

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massive gears rotating as the floor shifted in real-time, creating unpredictable layouts of spires, chasms, and jagged terrain. One slip-up and you could be crushed and lost forever to the inner workings. It wasn't unheard of.

Nearly a hundred hopefuls stood at the gate waiting for the entry horn. Each one a bundle of nerves wrapped in power. Some flexed their hands, crackling with energy. Others clutched weapons, eyes scanning for threats. A few stood blank-faced and frozen, their minds already in survival mode.

Myth. *No.*

Nyx walked quietly to the back of the group, calm. Her eyes scanned the crowd looking for anyone whose mutation might cause her problems. The nervous twitching male to her left was most likely a Nova-tier Kinetic. Powerful but unstable. The broad woman with spiked gauntlets? Probably an Amber-tier trying to break caste. She filed them away in her head one by one. She didn't want any unnecessary surprises.

High above the buzzing hopefuls, the Apex Corps stood elevated like divine executioners, perched on a seamless obsidian transport that jutted out over the arena like a blade. And standing at its heart was General Helios King. His exosuit glowing and catching every shred of light turning it a radiant kaleidoscope of rainbows. His polished gold Dominion markings and faint sunburst of stored Solar energy made him look like a god. He didn't move but his eyes swept across the candidates below, weighing their mutations against their souls.

To his left, Darius Valkyrie lounged with a soldier's indifference, armour jagged and dark like volcanic glass. His eyes flicked lazily across the field but beneath the surface tension was coiled like magma. Next to him, Eira Solaris stood like a glacier carved into humanoid shape. Her armour gleamed with frost and flames, her fingers lit with soft swirling blue fire. She was

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cold, beautiful, and ever so dangerous. Lynx Karien stood slightly away from King. His adaptive armour shimmering faintly with the shifting light signatures. Watching the field like a scholar instead of a lethal soldier. As if this was all just an equation he had to figure out. They were everything the AAN promised. The pinnacle of human evolution.

King raised a single hand and the crowd fell silent immediately waiting for his words. His voice rang out across the space like a clap of thunder. “Today,” he moved closer to the edge. “You will prove your worth. This is a measure of discipline, loyalty, adaptability and survival.” His tone sharpened. “The Apex Corps does not reward potential, only results. There is no quitting. There is only passing and failing.” He waved his hand towards the gears, making his meaning clear. With a sharp blinding light from his hand, “Let the trials **begin!**” he announced.

At his command, the arena came alive with a mechanical scream. The floor shuddered beneath their feet as panels buckled and rose, hissing out steam and exhaust. A jagged labyrinth formed in seconds, metal ribs grinding into place blocking and twisting corridors. Platforms spun, snapped and folded with unpredictable rhythm, revealing hidden ledges, walls, and collapsing halls. Holograms flickered into place overhead, projections sharp and clear showcasing every inch of the arena. Combat drones shaped like giant bats with wings whirring with glowing red sensors flooded the arena, locking onto every single hopeful.

Nyx inhaled deeply then burst forward. She felt the fear rippling through the crowd as she moved through the chaos. The hopefuls scattered for cover, energy flaring across every inch of the combat field. Drones screamed from above, firing plasma bolts so hot the air turned white in places, while others deployed electrified nets or shields that pulsed just out of reach like bait. The sky above turned into a grid showing the contestants and their ranking. Right now it was in enlistment order but numbers were already dwindling.

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Nyx moved sharp and silent. One hopeful to her left lunged for a hovering shield drone and took a bolt directly to the chest, blood spraying everywhere while his body spiralled back in a choked gasp. Nyx quickly shielded herself with her power as she watched someone to her side get caught in a gravity snare, his limbs crushing inward as he was dragged into the floor screaming. She vaulted herself out of the area as she felt a drone lock onto her. She felt the energy charge just before the blast fired. She lifted her hand, quick and easy. Energy like this was best to just return, she thought, biting her cheek. The drone buckled and morphed before exploding in a shower of light at the return of energy. She breathed and hurried on, searching the field for opponents. Drones shrieked diving for her, raining down a barrage of energy and lethal bullets. She didn't aim; she just threw raw curling energy like a long spear of alloy straight into them before raising an overhead shield and kept moving. The drones screamed across the arena before crashing into a wall and exploding.

“Show-off.”

She heard him before she saw him. A ripple in the area, a distortion above her shoulder. Nyx turned her head slightly. Floating above the ground, balanced and poised, was Synn Astra. According to the rankings, he was a gravity-weaver. He had soft eyes and his lopsided grin told her he was having fun. He hovered and dodged drones lazily before vanishing upwards, leaving a trail of gentle laughter in his wake. She fought the smile threatening to form on her face. His laugh was infectious.

A bolt of electric blue carved across the sky above and she focused again. The source was Taryn Faye; her blue hair whipped behind her, her movement so fast Nyx had a hard time tracking her. Soundwaves burst in arcs from her hands, visible ripples that knocked hopefuls back. A sonic scream took out a trio at once.

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Nyx went around the fray, grabbing material beneath her hand, feeling it bend and curve then reforming into floating stepping stones as she got closer to the centre of the field. She looked at the rankings again. She needed to move up faster and she hated being toyed with like this. Was she just supposed to obliterate all other contenders in the first round... She shook her head.

Surely not.

Another competitor, Cyris Zehn, charged at her with Kinetic speed, his movements a blur as his quirk boosted his momentum. Nyx stood her ground, watching him close the distance with lightning speed. At the last moment, she flicked her fingers, and the ground beneath him shifted. His enhanced momentum worked against him as he stumbled into a cleverly reshaped ledge, losing control and tumbling into a glowing plasma net that ensnared him instantly.

Darius leaned forward, arms crossed on the railing surveying the Testing Grounds, the volcanic glow under his skin burning brighter with each passing moment. “She’s not even struggling,” he muttered half under his breath. The suspicion in his voice wasn’t subtle.

Beside him, Eira didn’t blink but her gaze never left the girl. “Too powerful to be a Luminal-tier. I don’t buy it,” she said quietly.

Lynx stood still off-centre, his head tilted slightly. “What does her dossier say?” he asked, his voice low and calm. “She’s probably some Apex reclusive prodigy.”

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Eira went to pull up her AAN dossier on her link but was met with an immediate, glaring **CLASSIFIED**. She didn't say anything, but Darius felt the temperature around him drop significantly, causing his body to give off a slight hiss of steam. He tried not to laugh as his eyes flicked to King, but his mirth died instantly. King was standing more rigid than normal, leaning forward slightly. His eyes narrowed to slits watching as the contestants stopped trying to attack her and focused on not being crushed by the field, but she was relentless. It seemed like her mutation didn't have a lot, if any, counters. Her name ticked to the top of the ranks and Darius noted that instead of her mutation index it just showed "Unclassified".

Eira huffed, particles of ice flying from her mouth. "So which is it? Classified or Unclassified?"

"Be serious. Now," King snapped, walking back to his seat. "This isn't the time."

Darius rolled his eyes and turned away. It seemed like King had a larger stick than normal up his butt today. He was itching to check this girl's dossier but he knew he would be met with the same glaring red warning as Eira. They would just have to wait and see because she clearly was going to win. Around her, there were only a handful of survivors that remained and it seemed more in a friendly way. She seemed unsure and unaware that it was a free-for-all. That means she didn't have any inside help on that end, then. He was intrigued and he wasn't sure he liked that.

Nyx stood still in the dust and ruin of the area waiting for the buzzer. Victory didn't feel like victory. Not with the rest of the hopefuls avoiding her like a plague and there was no way to

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fight them without giving away more of her powers. The fear in their eyes as they looked at her felt eerily familiar.

The horn split the silence and phase one was complete. A voice read out their rankings but Nyx barely listened. She was on top and that's all that mattered. Now she needed to stay there and she wasn't about to lose just to be liked.

The arena began to shift into the second phase as an AAN broadcast featuring something about King and teeth whitening played overhead. Gas hissed, and the entire field retracted, folding downward like a blooming metal flower before snapping shut again. She and the remaining contestants did everything they could not to get crushed as they were sucked through segmented walkways and dropped hard into the glowing maze of corridors.

A voice rang out overhead:

“Phase two: Adaptation. Proceed through your assigned corridor. Each chamber contains a challenge. Failure to solve the challenge within the time frame will result in elimination. Time is active: **Now.**”

The lights flickered red, white, and then vanished as the buzzer sounded. Nyx moved; she felt rushed. She knew this would be a possibility, but the challenges ranged per cycle year and were rarely repeated. She felt her heart pounding in her ears as her eyes scanned the shifting architecture. The walls hummed and curved and she felt like she was in an endless hive. She swallowed the rising panic and thought of Vexal. Of Lyra and Korric. Of Tarja and the others. Her pulse slowed and she felt herself calm down as she saw the first puzzle up ahead. She breathed a sigh of relief. It was a pattern sequence and sigils requiring flawless reaction speed. She knew this. She rapidly finished the test and proceeded onto the next chamber and felt her

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ears ring again. In front of her was a terminal spewing smoke and sparks and enough tech malfunctions to let her know one wrong move and half the arena would probably detonate.

She moved before she thought, her hand sliding into the guts of the machine. Her dark energy crawled over the components as she rerouted the power away from the core into herself and forced the terminal into override. It hummed and then stabilised before dying. She withdrew her hand as the overhead light blinked green. She dashed through the corridor as the one behind her folded back into the wall.

Screams echoed from somewhere. Seems like one hopeful was already gone. She glanced up at the rankings just in time to see him dragged through a trapdoor after failing a challenge. She shook her head and focused. At a side junction, she saw Taryn Faye blast a holographic trap apart with a ripple of sonic force before bouncing into the main corridor. “Well hiya Nyx!” she called out with a grin, running beside her in a haze of smoke and blue light. Nyx gave her a lopsided smile before reaching out her hand and using her powers to vault Taryn over a rising wall as she used her other hand to melt through with ease. Taryn yelped but regained her footing and kept running, her eyes wide. “Thanks!” she called.

“No problem,” Nyx said. She didn’t do it to help, though. Depending on the next area, having an extra body might be crucial. As she reached the end of the corridor, the walls dissolved into light and the ground flickered to life into a full holographic city simulation. A destroyed city. Collapsed buildings, screaming civilians and fire everywhere. Nyx felt bile rise in the back of her throat at the realistic footage and the speaker spat to life overhead:

“Phase three: Crisis response. Prioritize civilian survival. Minimize collateral damage. Drones are active. Environment rating: Hostile. Begin.”

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The field erupted into pandemonium and Nyx felt her body fly forward having no choice but to turn a falling building into faint fog to keep from being crushed. A child hologram whimpered below her and she tried to steady herself. She had to focus. She tagged the child safe and started forward rapidly. She ran her hands over everything, turning things into dust, absorbing it all. It didn't feed her but it certainly didn't hurt her and this was the swiftest way forward. Overhead she felt a drone lock on and fire. She caught the plasma in mid-air and absorbed it and then returned it, exploding the drone in mid-air. Synn Astra hovered nearby, struggling to lift a section of wall pinning two virtual survivors.

"Need a hand?" she called out.

He glanced at her, sweat streaming down his brow. "Though it pains me. Yes."

She immediately launched herself under the platform. The second it came in contact with her, it dissolved away and she checked the survivors safe. He gave her a thumbs up and lifted her out in time to see Taryn scream precise pulses that neutralised some nearby traps.

Bryn Alaric crawled somewhere like a ghost, his shadows showing up here or there to help a survivor, but Synn's and Nyx's scores dominated. Working together, they found the majority of the survivors in record time, shuttling them both to the top of the Apex Training rankings.

The final test was a chamber sealed in steel. At its centre, a shattered energy reactor sparked wildly unstable, raw and very deadly. The walls hissed with suppressed charge and three drones spun on the ceiling above, arming slowly. A red light pulsed throughout the room, feeding the feeling of panic. It was clear, Nyx gulped, failure meant detonation.

"Get it online," Bryn snapped, already unfurling a dome of blackened smoke trying to block the ceiling turrets without any success.

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“I’ll stall the time!” Taryn said, throwing her back against a wall and started launching short bursts of sound that turned the rapid second countdown timer into at least a few minutes.

Synn floated to the centre, hauling scattered pieces of the reactor into alignment with his gravity powers. Nyx could see his arms shaking from exertion. She knew she shouldn’t absorb her way out of this but it seemed unlikely that all the pieces would stay together on their own. She started transforming; maybe she could make a new one. Or one that looked enough like the original to pass. Her hand shook hard as she connected with the power core; with exact movements, she folded it in on itself and started reshaping from the inside out. She heard Synn relax and realised she had been squeezing her eyes closed. Looking down, the reactor looked good as new. As soon as she withdrew her hand, the room was flooded with bright green light and the drones powered down. The walls slowly receded and they were raised amidst a flood of cheers and thrown gold confetti. Taryn exhaled loudly and gave Nyx a crooked nod. “Not bad, not bad Nyx!”

Bryn flicked her shoulder lightly and Nyx couldn’t help the smile on her face as she brushed a strand of violet-streaked hair back. They had made it through! She knew Vexal had been watching and could hardly contain the excitement, not knowing what he thought. Whenever she had actual privacy, she had a comtech channel she could reach him on, but that seemed like it was going to be a bit yet. Her eyes narrowed slightly and the smile felt frozen on her face as the Apex Corps platforms rapidly descended towards them. She clenched her jaw and kept her smile on her face. She won and that’s what mattered for now.

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King was impatient. They had watched the trial, following Nyx's every move. King had gone from concerned to properly worried. Whoever's prodigy this was, was a threat to all of their positions. Her "Dark Transformation" mutation seemed to have no limit. Not only that, but he was sure she had been holding back the whole time. Mutations were rarely one-shot branches and he just knew she was hiding something. He felt the platform come to a gentle halt and slapped his best citizen-forward smile on his face.

Nyx stood still, not celebrating like the others, her silver eyes unreadable and boring into him. He felt a chill crawl up his side, but Eira was hanging off him as usual. He resisted the urge to huff and cleared his throat. "Nyx." His voice smooth and cool. "You are the victor."

A ripple of applause drifted through the stadium and quieted again. "To the rest of you, you've proven yourselves worthy of the AAN. You will all begin training immediately. Never fail, never surrender. Hail Titan!" He saluted and the crowd erupted in a violent cheer. The new cadets saluted and marched away in a flurry of smiles and cheers. He felt Lynx next to him slightly power his Null field. King hadn't felt himself flare but he took a deep breath anyway. Raising his arms to the crowd, he smiled and waved with the others. As soon as their platform redocked out of sight, his smile dropped. Eira looked at him sceptically, but he avoided her gaze. He didn't need her nosing around right now, he thought as he stalked towards his office. What he needed was to find out who Nyx belonged to. None of the other cadets would have made it through the final trial. They weren't supposed to make it through the final trial. He felt his arm prick and tried to shove the doctor's words to the back of his mind. He needed to focus on one thing at a time. And right now, that was him staying on top.

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Nyx was relieved even though she could barely see around the electric blue hair in front of her. Taryn was dancing and jumping in excitement as soon as they were out of sight and Nyx had to smile. The applause could still be heard from above as they moved through the exit tunnels and they waved and nodded to the tech or congratulatory guard.

“Well!” Taryn said, turning to her excitedly, “aren’t you just a bag full of tricks!” she squealed.

Nyx grinned at her excitement, shrugging. “Couldn’t let you guys outshine me now, could I? Scream queen?”

Taryn blushed deep burgundy at the compliment and Nyx noticed how well her dark skin and blue hair went together.

“Outshine nothing!” Synn Astra chipped in, flicking her on the shoulder from behind. “That was amazing! What tier are you?”

She was saved from answering by Bryn who spoke to her for the first time. “Yeah, I haven’t seen a mutation like that. It’s not natural.”

“Neither is shadow weaving,” she shot back with a laugh. Bryn blinked at her, slightly taken aback.

“Fair,” he finally said grudgingly, turning away as they were led off the transport and into the inner gates of the Apex Corps campus. The towering walls of reinforced obsidian glass met them coldly and beyond, the Kinetic training fields sparked with barely contained energy. Pristine corridors of polished white alloy humming with concealed tech wound through the facility.

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Nyx fought to keep her jaw in place at such opulence. It was like being inside a monument. Darius Valkyrie appeared out of a side hall and headed off the group, and they trailed silently. Eira joined the group as well and she and Darius talked in hushed voices. She tried to ignore it and instead focused on the glinting statues of Apexs that lined what she assumed was the main hall.

The semi-tour ended in a crystalline dining hall that looked like it had been carved from starlight. Long tables glistened beneath hanging aurora-threaded chandeliers. The food was unreal to look at as the sweet-smelling air wafted under her nose. Real food, real proteins and starches, fresh produce. She felt her mouth water and tried to look instead outside, out over Helion Prime. Apex protégés would be used to this lifestyle, she reminded herself. She went to her place at the table, or so was indicated by a small gold card. Taryn took the place beside her and it seemed like her luck was holding out because Synn Astra had sat with Bryn on the far side. At the head of the table sat Eira and Darius and a few empty seats; she assumed the other members weren't going to join them. Darius waited until they had found their spot before standing and crossing his arms.

"You earned your place at this table," he said bluntly. "**Barely**. Don't mistake that for anything more. You still have to earn your place among us. Your rank. And respect. The real trials start now." He sat down without a flourish and started eating. Eira rolled her eyes but nodded to the cadets.

Nyx took the hint and dug in like the rest. The food was delicious but it still didn't do anything more for her than wet her tongue. But the sounds that Taryn was making would make anyone believe she was raised on the outskirts and hadn't tasted food before.

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Taryn caught her look and assumed it was for the speech. “Isn’t he a charmer?” she muttered just loud enough for Nyx to hear.

Nyx leaned slightly toward her. “Riveting,” she deadpanned.

Synn snorted hard, trying to stifle a laugh.

Darius glanced up from his plate. “Problem?”

“Not at all!” Synn said, grinning.

Darius nodded and stood with Eira, nodded again and walked off with Eira heading in the opposite direction. Once they were gone, tension broke at the table. Laughter spread like a warm front and drink and food were passed around. Taryn recounted how she blasted a trap so hard they had given her a warning not to create structural damage.

Bryn dryly added, “Ah yes the, ‘don’t take everyone down with you’ warning!”

Nyx felt a real laugh pour out of her. “Must be a common occurrence if it didn’t even make the announcements.”

Taryn flicked her shoulder playfully. “Hey now, everybody has their hearing intact, I call that a win!”

Synn raised a glass to his ear. “Eh? Can’t hear ya!” he shouted. Taryn laughed loudly, causing the glass in the hall to vibrate slightly. They all grabbed their glasses in fake fear before laughing even harder.

“Oh, it’ll be fine!” Taryn said, tossing a cherry fruit at Nyx. “You can just fix literally anything, I guess?”

Nyx laughed full-heartedly. “If only! I was sweating there!”

“This close,” Taryn raised her hands. “To being a voided bedtime story.”

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“Okay! Not funny!” Bryn said, trying to pull a straight face but failing miserably. “I was going to be so disappointed. Not even mad. Just disappointed.”

Nyx’s cheeks hurt from how hard she was laughing and Taryn stood up, brandishing a fake bow. “Oh my Titan!” she exhaled in mock wonder. “Death was painful but oh, the pain of your disappointment!” She reached to the sky. “My heart!”

Nyx felt tears streaming down her face. She had never laughed so hard she cried. But here it seemed almost... normal? They stayed up well into the night hours, relishing their victory and guessing at tomorrow. When they finally retired for the night, still laughing, Nyx looked over her quarters and it was like a splash of ice in her face. The sleek, clean and arguably perfect environment was almost too much for her eyes. She knew she couldn't be thrown off, being unfamiliar with a dorm would definitely draw red flags. She went to her luggage and started unpacking. Thankfully the list of things to bring was short and she didn't have a lot of personal items. When she was done she stepped into the showers and breathed a sigh of relief. Plausible privacy, right? She shuffled into the shower and stripped, pulling out her comtech Vexal had given her from an inside pocket. It was actually very encouraged to bring personal tech here. She had the traditional two comtechs. One for alleged family and personal life and the other for professional use. But it was heavily monitored and from what Vexal said, while their things sat in their rooms they had been definitely rooted through and bugged. Even this wasn't entirely safe but she needed to check in. More for her than him. She powered it up and soon the glow flickered across her face. She typed quickly:

They have accepted me, I think.

There was a pause before it buzzed quietly against her fingertips.

Good job. You did good today. Stay alert. Don't let them catch you off guard.

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She wanted to type more but really couldn't risk it. She deleted the messages and powered the device off before placing it back in her pockets. She quickly showered and then laid down on the firm silk bed. It was so quiet and sterile. Nothing like the Big O. She hadn't thought she would miss it so strongly but it was her only real home, she thought as she tossed trying to get comfortable. Guilt gnawed at her; she was here enjoying this perfect environment while her friends, her family had to suffer below in the Undercity. And she had found herself liking these people. Taryn, Synn, Bryn. She could never let Vexal know that her mask wasn't entirely fake. She fought back tears and steeled her resolve as she drifted off to sleep. She was on a mission and she would not fail.

Chapter 8

The dormitory lights flicked on brightly and a high-pitched bing sounded through the room. Nyx bolted upright, her breath caught in her throat, her dreams chased away by the overhead voice:

“CADETS. UNIFORMED IN FIFTEEN. INSPECTION, MESS, THEN THE DTC AT HOUR 7.”

Nyx scrambled up. That wasn't a lot of time considering how big this place was. Her room was already ready for inspection. She made sure her comtech was thoroughly secured, dressed in her uniform and headed into the mess hall. Taryn was the only other woman on the women's side, but Nyx wasn't sure exactly where her room was, so she didn't wait.

When she finally reached the mess hall, she was surprised to see it spread with heaps of delicious food. More than they could possibly eat in two sittings. Nyx refused to let her face

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change and packed a decent-sized plate. At least it wouldn't be totally wasted on rubbish chutes. She wondered why they didn't give it to the Undercity but shook her head as she spotted Synn. He looked barely awake as he floated a few inches off the floor, his chair a polite suggestion that he ignored. She rolled her eyes slightly at him and felt a weird flutter of relief as Taryn finally came stomping in, still strapping her shoulder pieces together. Kicking out a chair with one boot, she flopped down with a sigh. "Bryn got lost on the way," she said flippantly, not explaining how she knew that, but lo and behold, he trailed in a bashful cloud of shadows as if on cue.

Nyx didn't even know what to think and just smiled instead as they helped themselves to the table. She moved her jaw in action while trying to simulate eating the proper amount of food. Vexal had said they go off of how much energy you have, and if she was reported not eating, that would raise definite flags.

A Dominion Instructor strode into the hall, her crimson-edged uniform gleaming beneath the lights. "Eat fast. It's Demo Day." She turned on her heel and disappeared without another word. Nyx quickly shovelled the rest of her plate in her mouth and the others followed suit. Once they were done, they headed to the massive Dominion Training Convergence. An arena encased in the strongest graphene plating and black obsidian, its structure flexing with buried Kinetic stabilisers designed to endure Quasar-tier energy bursts. Even the air itself thrummed with power. Inside was even more impressive, and above them, on the observation tier, stood the Apex elites and their Dominion counterparts.

Lynx Kairen was hard to miss: tall, controlled, his Nullify-field shimmering faintly around his olive skin, a stark contrast from his onyx and blue AAN Dominion uniform. Next to him, Rhea Vaelith looked like a goddess. So beautiful it was almost painful, her green armour

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almost indistinguishable from her skin, and she looked completely unaffected by Kairen's Nullify-field.

Then there was Commander Thal Voxx. Nyx tried not to stare. His seven-foot-tall height made him look more imposing in person than on screen. Framed in white and gold, his Razorflight wings were folded behind his back like a throne. His white eyes scanning the cadets showed no emotion, his face never moving.

Nyx gulped as she felt his eyes on her, and she focused ahead. She already knew who was lurking at his side. A chill crawled up her back as she eyed the hunched figure. Dr. Varian Ekros. The Cherry Rat. AAN's most questionable employee by far. He didn't move, didn't blink, just smiled down at them through his cherry-red lenses, fingers clasped tightly in front of him in his awful teal gloves, as if he was looking at a bunch of rats to dissect. Nyx could feel his eyes raking over her, smiling at her. She shuddered again and forced herself not to look in his direction as the roll was called. This was undoubtedly going to be worse than the Entrance Exams. There was no passing here, no fans, no public opinion. It was just them against their Dossiers. Vexal had made sure hers stayed Unclassified. That way she didn't have to match up to anything and she could show whatever she felt comfortable with. This was also where the Trainers and the Apex scouted out who would be under their 'Dominion'. She felt her palms prickle and her pulse speed up. She knew her every move was about to be dissected.

They were called out by tier, lowest to highest to unclassified. The arena shifted, the polished alloy floor now forming a perfect ring of concentric plates. Above them, behind a reinforced transparent barrier, sat the AAN Council. Even though the barrier was transparent and the shadowing of the room obscured their faces, their presence was undeniable.

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Commander Voxx stood at the edge of the central platform, his white command coat almost sparkling in the light. “This is a Tier-evaluation,” he said, his voice echoing through the arena on the speakers. “You are to demonstrate your absolute threshold. What you show us today will define your Mutation Index going forward. You have five minutes each.”

A mechanical hum surged through the floor as the reinforced plate barriers slid into place in preparation for the first cadet.

“Bryn Elisar Alaric. Amber-tier,” Voxx called out. Bryn stepped forward, his shadow trailing behind him slightly, his dark armour catching none of the overhead light as he stepped to the centre.

“Codename: Nightshade,” Voxx continued. “Primary Ability: Shadowforge.”

As soon as the buzzer sounded, Bryn flew into action. His hands moved fluidly, and the shadows around him sprang to life. Weapons, constructs, humanoid silhouettes, all sprang to life like mist as the arena lights were dimmed to complement his powers. The dimmer the light got, the more terrifying and enormous his manifestations became. His secondary manifestations kicked in, cloaking him completely, leaving the power meter to tick higher and higher until the very walls were shaking with force. When the buzzer finally went off and he revealed himself, he looked completely unfazed, his shadows slowly retreating even in the full light.

Voxx’s voice echoed out: “Clearance raised. Authorization: Black Trace. Assigned division: Covert Operations. Infiltration, Recovery and Erasure.”

Nyx let out her breath slowly. Black Trace for a cadet was insane. That meant one thing: he was considered useful, dangerous, a spy. And seeing the extent of his mutation, she knew she would have to always be on the lookout for misplaced shadows.

The floor reset as Commander Voxx gave the next name. “Taryn Keziah Faye.”

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She strutted out like she was walking into a club, her blue hair spiked and wild, her body clearly buzzing.

“Codename: Sonique,” Voxx said. “Mutation Tier: Nova. Primary Ability: Sonic Rend.”

Nyx braced herself just in time. As Taryn raised her hands, the air vibrated violently, a deep thrumming tone blasting their ears before the arena’s sound-dampeners kicked in. Still, Nyx could feel her teeth ache from the vibration as the practice drones shattered overhead. She saw one AAN figure flinch. Taryn quickly moved into her secondary abilities using vocal whipstrikes, echo burst propulsion, sonic mirages before Voxx cut her off abruptly with a sharp hand, ending the demonstration two minutes early. They all looked at him questionably, but he had a foul look on his face.

“Control issues,” Commander Voxx said flatly. “Tier: Unchanged. Nova. Note: Testing for Apex Eligibility. Pending decibel compliance.”

Taryn’s face stayed stoic as she saluted, but her walk back definitely showed she felt stilted. Nyx felt a tug of sympathy but then remembered what they were all here training for and the feeling died instantly. Plus, a mutation like that bordered Dreg-level considering the amount of discomfort it caused everyone's ears.

“Synn Erdos Astra.” Commander Voxx’s voice rang out over the change of the arena.

Synn cracked his knuckles as he stepped forward. Gone was the joking, brazen boy; in his place stalked a cold, calculating man.

“Codename: Loworbit. Mutation Tier: Amber. Primary Ability: Gravity Flux.”

Synn raised one hand and the entire arena began to cave inward with a metallic shriek before what felt like a reverse explosion hit them, raising the emergency gravity shields and

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causing everyone to brace themselves. Both Commander Voxx and Dr. Vaelith moved forward as if to get a better look.

Synn floated slowly upward, orbiting drones and practice debris around him like a tornado while a ring of fragmented plate shards formed, poised and ready to attack.

“He wasn’t like this at the trials,” Nyx muttered to herself. He had held back, a lot. As he continued to perform feats of nature, the evaluators murmured continuously, obviously impressed.

After the buzzer went off, Commander Voxx called, “Tier elevated. Mutation Tier: Nova.”

Applause rang from behind the AAN viewing room. “Division: Apex Training Corps. Ascendant upon Apex Trial Clearance. Well done, Astra.”

Synn fought to hide his grin as he saluted and walked back to his place in line. She could feel Taryn bristle beside her, but she couldn’t focus on that now. It was her turn. She stepped forward and into the arena as Commander Voxx called out, “Nyx.” His voice was flat as he looked for the rest of her name.

“Mutation Tier: Unclassified. Status: Unregistered. Codename: Nyx.” He was practically spitting now. She knew not being classified was unusual but it wasn’t unheard of, she had thought. She glanced up at the view panel, her heartbeat thrumming in her ears. After the last demonstration and how they treated Taryn, she knew the plan to lay low was off the table. It was time to let loose.

Nyx lifted her hands and she felt her power surge from her palms, a pulsing wave of living void rippling through the arena like ink spilled across steel. The pristine arena floor groaned and warped, the safety protocols blinking red before being completely overridden.

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Gleaming alloys shattered into brittle shards, then regrew into massive jagged ridges and pitch-black spires that crawled along the walls like a corrupted biome.

The Dominion Trainers surged to the edge of the platform above, no longer feigning their interest beneath masks of rank and protocol. Even the dark-paneled glass shielding the AAN Council chamber hissed upward, retracting to reveal the gathered members now pressing forward against the observation rail.

Nyx pushed herself up above the chaos she had made and started pulling from the walls whirling vortexes of metallic razors, the shriek of metal carving through the air. She dropped Kinetic mines disguised as petals. Beautiful, delicate things that floated down gently before detonating with enough force that the arena trembled on its foundations. She painted throughout the chaos trees, blooming flowers, living people, all made from the dust and shimmer only to be swept away by her whirling purple tide.

She couldn't help the grin on her face. She was able to use her power as freely and as widely as she wanted. She hadn't even dared this kind of freedom in the Undercity, always scared of setting off any energy sensors. But here they wanted to see her power, and from the greedy looks on their faces, all of it.

She felt time crack as she froze the spinning vortex, dust still in place, like a frozen holograph that had been put on pause. Then she warped. First beside Commander Voxx with a sharp salute as he startled back, his wings coming out to the ready. Then she was gone and she was in the AAN observation chamber. She saluted the flinching and scattering leaders. Then she reappeared at the far side of the arena before vanishing to a Luminial market. She stood for half a second and snagged the day's datapost from a stall and returned amidst the stunned civilians. She

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landed softly back in front of Commander Voxx and placed the newspaper gently into his hands. His jaw hung slightly open and the room went dead silent.

She shifted back to the centre of the arena for her final trick. She was going to make a construct. Not like the one that ran rampant at the market. This one was fire-born, purple and orange flame licking around behemoth magma arms. Each step sizzled, shaking the stone arena floor. As it grew and towered, radiant heat bellowed off it, causing the walls to slowly turn to alloy sludge.

Out of the corner of her eye, she saw a flurry of movement from the observation deck. Kairen was standing with his arms outstretched in her direction. She could see his Nullify-field activating and her monster shuddered but held. She flinched involuntarily as she felt her ribs cinch tight, like she was being squeezed by an invisible steel fist. Her mutation flared against the suppression, quickly overriding him and knocking him to his knees. She lowered herself to the ground, her eyes not leaving his, and clapped her hands together once. The buzzer blared and the arena became smooth and sterile once more. Her monster was gone in a blink, the walls restored, and the temperature quickly returned to normal again.

She stood seething, trying to control her heart rate. “If you wanted me to stop,” she bit out, “you could’ve just said. Sir.” She saluted and marched back to her place with a click of her heels. She avoided the terrified gaze of the other cadets and stared off into the distance as she waited for her tier to be called.

For what felt like an eternity, nobody moved, nobody spoke. Not the instructors, not the cadets, not even the AAN Council. Finally they moved as the upper glass of the AAN observation deck hissed upward slowly, closing off the rising buzz of conversation. Commander Voxx cleared his throat and stepped forward, his boots clicking slightly. The serrated shimmer of

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his wings dimmed as he folded them behind his back, his voice coming out like thunder. “Nyx,” he called. “Codename: Starlight Ruin.”

She felt her heartbeat pick up in her throat, but she forced her face not to move.

“Mutation Tier: Quasar,” Commander Voxx continued, his gaze so sharp she felt a shiver down her spine. “Primary Ability One: Dark Transformation. Primary Ability Two: Temporal Rift. Primary Ability Three: Spatial Warp.”

He paused a beat. “Assigned Division: Apex Corps. You are to begin joint training immediately in preparation for field integration. You are all dismissed.” He gave a precise salute before stalking off in a flurry of white. The Dominion Trainers immediately followed him and Nyx turned on her heel, making for the exit as well. It seems, she thought, she was wrong about going all out. Was that even all out? She mused as she fought the urge to want to disappear entirely. Footsteps caught up behind her quickly, but the voices that came were anything but bitter.

“Okay, that was sick!” Taryn said, running up beside her, slightly jogging sideways to keep up with her pace. “Look, I get it, not everyone wants their ears shattered in order to be saved. Titan be blessed,” she cracked.

Nyx blinked and then smiled widely at her. “Hey, at least we will always know where to find you,” she quipped.

Taryn laughed, the sound actually comforting after the quiet of the arena. Nyx turned as Synn and Bryn caught up, animated and buzzing with energy. Synn was back to his old self, lazing around floating in his own pool of gravity. “Now that was a ranking! Not even waiting for the cycle vote. Quasar-tier immediately! Vaporised! They were vaporised!” He clapped, twisting in flips in the air. She laughed at his antics, the tension leaving her shoulders. Bryn didn’t say

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anything but he nodded in agreement enthusiastically as he walked up, giving her a smile. He looked worn out from his demonstration, and she remembered it would be weird if she didn't eat. As she started towards the mess hall, Synn caught her attention. "So. Question. Can you... like... warp other people?"

Nyx hesitated. "I don't know. Maybe."

"Oooh!" Taryn squealed. "We are going to test that! Sneaking out just levelled up!"

Nyx laughed at that; she hadn't even thought of something like sneaking out after working so hard to get in. They moved like a unit now, drifting into the mess hall where the scent of food was almost overwhelming. Trays of nutrient-rich meals, glowing protein gels, and steaming plates waited.

"You've got to be starving!" Synn said, already piling up his plate. Nyx nodded but she didn't feel hungry. Especially after what she had taken from Vexal. His energy still hummed low and strong beneath her skin. She grabbed a plate and filled it absentmindedly. They chatted and talked like friends while they ate. Swapping jokes and stories, but even through it all, she couldn't shake the gnawing feeling in the back of her mind.

Chapter 9

The AAN and Apex Corps were in an uproar. Darius stood alone in the lower-floor observation deck, a place most didn't even know existed in the pursuit to be at the top, and it was far beneath the Council wing. But it was the perfect space needed to think, observe uninterrupted, to study. And as for what had happened today, he hadn't wasted a moment after the cadets were dismissed. As their light-hearted laughter echoed as they left the arena, he was already on the platform to the secured Council chamber.

Inside was mayhem. Two AAN board members were yelling over each other, arguing so fast their words blurred together. Ice covered the farthest part of the room where Eira stood in a swirling storm that whipped and wrapped around her body in jagged bursts. Darius bit back the urge to smirk; she clearly feared being replaced. Seconds later, the door parted with a regal hum

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of authority. King strode into the room with Kairen at his tail, both men so vastly different but equally disturbed. At their entrance, the greying High Chancellor Mereen raised her hands. The room fell slowly quiet. She cleared her throat, her voice calm but possessing the lilt of someone who was used to being obeyed.

“Commander Voxx,” she said. “Why don’t you finish reading her updated dossier. I think that we can all agree that yes, the other hopefuls did fine, wonderful even, but we are all only really here for one reason.”

Commander Voxx gave a stiff nod, his expression stony. He pulled up his comtech and tapped through several encrypted screens. In the silence they waited: one, two, three. Each layer demanding higher clearance until the final screen required both his and the Council leader’s biometric code.

Triple-classified? Darius thought. *In order to have an AAN Council leader’s biometric code, it had to have been sealed by one. So why were they acting like they knew just as much as the Corps did?*

Commander Voxx’s voice finally started. “Candidate Nyx. Legal designation is confirmed...” He paused his face scrunching. “Energy Type: Anomalous. Tri-fused configuration. Temporal, spatial, and entropic conversion. Mutation Tier: Quasar-tier. Classification: Apex-Anomaly hybrid. Psych profile... incomplete. Family and origin, unknown. Current record suggests she emerged from a sanctioned biotech testing facility, though it's currently non-operational.” He threw his comtech, clearly frustrated.

Lynx scoffed, standing up. “She’s a **fake**! A fabrication! That just doesn’t exist! My field should’ve shut her down completely. She didn’t even shudder!” He slammed his fist into the

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table with a crack. Darius was surprised as King pulled him back into his chair. This was the most emotion he had seen out of Lynx in cycle years.

The Council leader held up a delicate hand and motioned to Commander Voxx to continue.

“She’s not fake,” Voxx continued. “Her power, at least, is very, very real from her readouts. We would have had more information...” He didn’t have to finish his thought. “There’s a data collapse listed here in part for the lack of background. Many citizens were affected; I’m sure you all remember it. More than information was lost. It was a massive blackout with massive intentional deletion. We still don’t know the full extent of the damage. It wiped out profiles tied to multiple test-born batches. Including one you might be familiar with.” He turned slightly, locking eyes with Eira. “Solaris,” he said, as if to clarify.

Eira looked like she might be sick and the ice around her deepened, webbing into deep fissures along the floor.

Commander Voxx’s eyes scanned the room again. “We don’t know her family, but that’s not important at this stage. Right now she’s not tracked, and she has no known weaknesses. We need to—”

“None?” It was King speaking up this time. “Surely that’s not right.”

“None,” Commander Voxx confirmed in a serious tone.

Darius almost smiled. So they were scared. Maybe he read her wrong, but she really didn’t seem malicious. The same couldn’t be said about one of the others.

“Warping?” Commander Voxx barked, suddenly shutting down his comtech and swivelling to the head Council man. “She warped through Quasar-tier Apex-grade barriers.

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Nullify-fields. Returned with civilian materials from sectors thousands of kilometres away. With seemingly no repercussions whatsoever!”

Silence settled on the room at his outburst. The High Chancellor's red lips were in a thin line, her knuckles white. “Your tone is not appreciated, Commander Voxx. But you are correct. And this...” She tapped the table with a stark finger. “This does not happen. Not even with a data breach does this at any stage fly under the radar. Something is very, very wrong. But the truth is—” She stood and walked over to the window, looking out at the arena. “She’s too valuable to lose and too much of a threat to anger.” She paused, turning to face them. “Commander Voxx, my all-knowingness has been a point of contention in the past, so know this. I do not know. I do not know her limits. I don’t know her motivation. We have raked her records dry and you saw the fruits of our labours. Nothing.”

King stalked to the head of the room. His golden skin shone in the reflection of Eira’s slightly out-of-control powers. He motioned to Darius, and he jumped up, going to stand at attention next to Eira, allowing his energy to quickly combat her ice and bring the room back up to a comfortable temperature again. She flashed him a small, grateful look.

Eira’s voice cut through the room. “So that’s it? She’s an Apex now? A part of the Corps just like that?”

“Not just like that,” the High Chancellor said coolly. “But yes. As of this moment, she is officially an Apex. She’s to be partnered with Valkyrie, effective immediately.”

Darius blinked, caught off guard. He had thought King, at least. With this close proximity, he could figure her out, though. Or just ask her directly. *Better and safer than spying*, his gut told him. He gave a snappy salute but said nothing. He felt Lynx’s glare and Eira’s cold presence biting at the air around him. They were both furious. Insulted, even.

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Dr. Ekros emerged from his chair in the corner and clapped his gloved hands together, his face bright with unnatural glee. “Oh, this is just delightful! I look forward to studying her closely.” He pulled his cherry-red glasses down slightly. “Very closely. I’ll need full access to her genomic readings, of course. Her stress charts... and—”

“Granted,” High Chancellor Mereen said with a wave of her hand, even though a few members murmured in protest. She stood and the others followed suit.

“Anything you find out, I want to my ears and my ears only.” And in a flurry of AAN capes and soft murmurs, they were gone.

Darius moved to leave, already feeling Eira getting madder and madder. He heard her call after him, but he was already out the door, past them all. He didn’t need the fallout of being the unlucky chosen one.

His boots echoed down the hollow corridor as he made his way to the cadet mess hall, fully expecting to find Nyx still eating. A display like that would’ve used up a massive amount of energy even for a Quasar-tier. Commander Voxx even needed a cooldown and replacement nutri-bars most days. As he walked into the mess hall, he was startled to find it empty. No sign of her or any of the other cadets. He felt his pulse quicken in his ears. *Oh dear Titan. She could warp, anywhere.*

He turned on his heel and jogged quickly down the women’s hallway, already trying to figure out how he would track her down if she wasn’t there. *They really should put some kind of tracker on her*, he mused. At least he could keep better track of her in the Apex wing. The room directly across from his had been vacant for months. He knew he should send her to the woman’s side, but no way in hell was Eira going to take that calmly. The living ice queen wasn’t known for her charm even on her best days. Putting them together... he tightened his jaw.

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He finally reached Nyx's door and rapped twice. Short and loud.

It swung in on the second knock, taking him off guard. He hadn't actually expected her to just... be in her room.

She was shorter than he expected. Much shorter; he had imagined she was Eira's height and she stood nearly eye-to-eye with him in her combat boots. He craned his head down.

She was looking up at him, patiently waiting with a smile on her face. "You look surprised to find me here," she finally said with a gentle laugh that made his heart skip unexpectedly.

Darius realised he had just been standing there, blinking like a glitching idiot. "Oh yeah. Just wasn't expecting..." He cleared his throat. "Anyway. So, we're a paired-team now. For training, I normally start my morning drills early. We need to work together and get our synergies down. Patrols are always joint, as you know, but since you're new-new... we'll just do drills and route familiarisation until you get the hang of it."

She smiled up at him, her silver eyes and white teeth a stark contrast to her virtually black skin. It was almost unnerving.

"Of course," she said lightly. "Just send the hours to my comtech."

She lifted her wrist and tapped it lightly to his, their devices linking with a soft chime.

"Done," he said, half-turning. "You also need to relocate. These dorms are for cadets. You're an Apex now."

She nodded. "Is there a specific room?"

"I'll show you." He led her in silence through the halls, up the more heavily secured corridor towards the Apex wing. Everything here was cleaner. Quieter. The hum of tech was perfectly calibrated for stronger energy profiles. No flickering lights. No damaged walls. Just

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sleek quartz walls and pearl panels, reinforced white-gold alloy doors, and a beautiful video of the Crown Canopy through the crystal glass windows.

He stopped in front of the suite opposite his. “This one,” he said simply. She stepped inside and looked around quickly before giving him a quiet nod.

“I’ll get my things,” she said, stepping back out.

He nodded once. “See you in the morning,” he said before turning to his room to change. He needed to burn some steam. Today had been *interesting*, to say the least. He changed quickly before making his way to the lower levels of the Dominion Training Centre, then out into the street.

The itch to destroy things pricked at the back of his mind as he used the common shuttles to cut through the Lower Luminal districts to get to Forgedeep. Keeping his head covered and down like he’d done a hundred times before, the air became increasingly thick with smoke and grime as he took the shuttles deeper. They finally dropped down a ledge near the dead freight rail and came to a slow stop at the opening into the Maw. The pulse of bass-rattles and the scrape of boots and the loud cheers of the crowd felt like home. He could smell the tinge of blood in the air and felt his mouth water.

The Ashbreaks were well underway. The winding vertical molten railings and ignited vents already had plenty of fallen hanging off, letting him know it had been a wild night already. The gambling den was screaming as the neon screens tracked the kill counts and credits. He made his way to the front and submitted his title, Heat Sovereign, and took his place on the line. Here he wasn’t an Apex captain; he wasn’t a symbol or a political talking point. He was just an Ashdog.

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The moment the buzzer went off, his boots left the platform and the world exploded around him. Blazing fire shot from both sides as he twisted mid-air, landing along a metal spine wider than his foot. Sparks burst beneath his weight, and the cheering from the spectators grew to a frenzy as it started to collapse. He felt the magma in his veins ignite as he launched off the spine into the frenzy of contestants below. With blissful brutality, he began ruthlessly slashing through the contestants with his magma blade. No reasons, no teams, just pure adrenaline and blood.